

Planning for your birth

As your due date approaches, you may start to think in greater detail about how you would like to manage your labor and birth. Being informed will help you feel more confident about the choices you make.

Your choices for birth

When planning the type of birth experience you would like to have, you'll need to consider a number of factors. One of the most important decisions is where you would like to give birth. You may also want to think about the details of your birth, such as which positions you would like to adopt during the birth, and what type of pain relief you might choose to use (see [Pain-relief options](#)).

It's important to be flexible. You may have preferences as to the type of birth you want, but accepting that your choice may be limited or advised against because of a preexisting medical problem, or because a problem arises in labor, will help you prepare mentally and curb disappointment if events don't go as planned. It is generally accepted that the care of healthy women in labor who have had a straightforward pregnancy should be monitored and managed by their doctors at the hospital, with support given by the nursing staff throughout the process.

The place of birth Earlier in pregnancy, you'll probably have thought about where you would like to give birth and discussed the options with your doctor. Although you may have already stated a preference, it's important to know that you can review your choice and change your mind toward the end of the pregnancy.

Where you give birth may be influenced by factors such as whether you've had complications in pregnancy, such as [gestational diabetes](#) or high [blood pressure](#), that would make a hospital birth preferable. On the other hand, if your pregnancy has been straightforward and you have become more informed about labor and birth over the course of your pregnancy, your confidence may have grown and you may decide to look into a home birth in familiar surroundings, or to investigate midwife-run birthing centers in your area.

An active labor In childbirth classes, you'll learn a range of techniques to help you cope with pain during labor. Most methods center around breathing and relaxation techniques that help you focus during labor and birth and don't inhibit movement. Maintaining mobility and an upright position during labor is thought to help you deal with contractions and to use gravity to help push your baby down the birth canal.

If you want an active birth, this may influence how you feel about the type of [pain relief](#) you want to use and about monitoring in labor. For example, continuous monitoring (see [External electronic fetal monitoring](#)) can limit your movement. If the